FAITH FOR EVERYDAY LIFE
GROUP GUIDE

grace groups

Week 2

This week, you'll recap how last week's spiritual practice went, discuss the biblical text and try another spiritual discipline. Please take time before your meeting to read, reflect and respond to the contents of the guide. Taking this step will deepen the group conversation.

Tip: Send this guide to everyone in your group before your meeting. Review the guide individually and then go through the questions together as a group when you gather. You won't get through every question—and that's okay. Let curiosity and conversation lead the way.

1. Was there anything from Sunday's message that stuck with you or challenged you? If so, what?

2. Last week, you were challenged to take one minute before starting your day to envision Jesus being present with you. What was the hardest part of trying this? What was the easiest?

3. If you tried this practice a few times, what was it like? Did you discover anything about yourself, God or the process?

Lectio Divina

Lectio Divina emphasizes a "dialogue with the text". It is about patient receptivity and openness more than a clamorous urgency to be enlightened.[1] Wanting to grasp everything immediately is the best way to comprehend nothing.

As you prepare independently before your group, you are encouraged to pause before you read the passage. Take a couple of slow, deep breaths. Say a short prayer, "God, open my eyes and ears to what you want to say." Read through the text slowly. Pause, then read the text again. When you arrive at your group, read through the passage once aloud and discuss the questions.

John 14:15-31 (NIV)

15 "If you love me, keep my commands. **16** And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another advocate to help you and be with you forever— **17** the Spirit of truth. The world cannot accept him, because it neither sees him nor knows him. But you know him, for he lives with you and will be in you. **18** I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you. **19** Before long, the world will not see me anymore, but you will see me. Because I live, you also will live. **20** On that day you will realize that I am in my Father, and you are in me, and I am in you. **21** Whoever has my commands and keeps them is the one who loves me. The one who loves me will be loved by my Father, and I too will love them and show myself to them."

22 Then Judas (not Judas Iscariot) said, "But, Lord, why do you intend to show yourself to us and not to the world?"

[1] A great resource for further study of *Lectio Divina* is *Sacred Reading* by Michael Casey.

[23] Jesus replied, "Anyone who loves me will obey my teaching. My Father will love them, and we will
come to them and make our home with them. [24] Anyone who does not love me will not obey my
teaching. These words you hear are not my own; they belong to the Father who sent me.
[25] "All this I have spoken while still with you. [26] But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will
send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you. [27] Peace I
leave with you; my peace I give you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be
troubled and do not be afraid.

[28] "You heard me say, 'I am going away and I am coming back to you.' If you loved me, you would be glad
that I am going to the Father, for the Father is greater than I. [29] I have told you now before it happens, so
that when it does happen you will believe. [30] I will not say much more to you, for the prince of this
world is coming. He has no hold over me, [31] but he comes so that the world may learn that I love the
Father and do exactly what my Father has commanded me. "Come now; let us leave.

4. What stood out to you from this week's text? Was there a word, phrase or image that caught your attention?

5. How might that word, phrase or image speak to something you are experiencing?

Background to the Text

These verses build on the main themes from John 14:1-14: Jesus' impending departure; the connection between Jesus and God, the Father; and, the ongoing presence of Jesus with His followers. John 14:15-31 explains how this is possible. Jesus explains that this ongoing relationship would be just like the one He has with the Father, God. Everything that He sees the Father doing (14:10-11) He does. He does nothing on His own, but only what the Father instructs.

The same was to be true of those who follow Jesus, they would follow the ways of Jesus. Their love for Him, is reflected by obeying (following) His commands (cf. Matthew 25:31-45; Galatians 5:22-25; Philippians 2:1-4; James 2:14-20). Love in this passage, reflects more than an emotional disposition but loyalty and faithfulness within a covenant.

The Holy Spirit is both super-natural and super-practical. In Hebrew, the term for spirit is *ruach*. It can be translated, "wind, breath, spirit, mind". For the ancient mind, especially the Hebrew mindset, the Holy Spirit is the life-giving and animating breath of God.

The term first appears in Genesis 1:2 where God's Spirit (*ruach*) is hovering over the chaotic waters and brings order to creation, it creates a place where life is possible. In the creation of humanity, the Spirit or breath of God is breathed into humanity, thus animating it (Genesis 2:7). It was the all-encompassing invisible force that caused things to come alive, and thus an extension of God Himself.

The concept of breath and wind were hard to describe. Just like wind and breath for the ancient, the role of the Holy Spirit today can be hard to define and explain. Though they couldn't see it, they could see the effects of the wind and breath that moved trees and caused the chest to rise and fall with each inhale and exhale.

John 14:15-31 picks up this theme. The Spirit of God, the Holy Spirit, would dwell within humanity once again. It would be the life-giving and animating force of God enabling, enfolding and enlivening the followers of Jesus to continue in His ways.[2] To walk in the truth.

6. If you grew up in church, how have you heard churches talk about the Holy Spirit?

7. What practical ways does John 14:15-31 say the Holy Spirit supports and comes alongside Jesus' followers?

8. Of the ways the Spirit supports Jesus' followers that you named in the last question, which one do you most need right now—and why?

Spiritual Practice:
Throughout this series you will be challenged to try to new practices. One of the practical aspects of the Holy Spirit is guiding Jesus' followers into truth through the Scriptures and words of Jesus.

> *"The Word of Scripture should never stop sounding in your ears and working in you all day long, just like the words of someone you love. And just as you do not analyze the words of someone you love, but accept them as they are said to you, accept the Word of Scripture and ponder it in your heart."*[3]

The ancient practice of meditating on Scripture creates within us a well from which the Holy Spirit can draw out (recall to mind) words of comfort, encouragement, strength and clarity.

9. What has been your experience with meditating on scripture? Have you seen times where that scripture has been recalled at the just right time?

Reading and reflecting on scripture is an act of discovery. The more time you spend with a particular text, the deeper you venture into its meaning and significance. Meaning and significance are two very different things. Often times we read for meaning, to gain information. However, the Holy Spirit wants us to move from simple meaning to understanding the text's significance for our lives, specifically who it

[2] A quick intro to the Holy Spirit can be found at https://bibleproject.com/guides/holy-spirit/. At this site, there is a short guide and video, but also additional links to deeper content.
[3] Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Theological Education at Finkenwalde: 1935–1937*, Dietrich Bonhoeffer Works vol. 14 (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2013), 174. (part of Bonhoeffer's work, *Life Together*)

is calling us to become. This week, you'll be challenged to read a text and ask yourself several questions that will help you move beyond meaning to significance.

You are encouraged to utilize the daily practice of gratitude, prayer and reading scripture on home page of the Grace App.[4] The emphasis for this practice will focus on reading scripture. Identify a quiet place and plan for about 5-7 minutes to engage this practice.

If you want to practice this as part of the group experience, you may want to begin with John 14:23-27.

Read the verses slowly two or three times. The Grace App already encourages you to read the passage slowly and listen for the word or phrase that speaks to you. This week, however, take it one step further. Instead of just writing down what stands out to you, reflect on these questions:

- How do I feel about what is being said? Where do I find myself resisting, pulling back or wrestling with what it might be saying? (Try to notice these inner dynamics without judging or analyzing them.)

- Why do I feel this way? What do my reactions tell me about myself—my attitudes, my relating patterns, my perspectives or my behaviors?

- What aspect of my life is being spoken to through this scripture?

In the journaling portion of the App, write down the word or phrase that stood out to you. Then put one or two sentences about why that word/phrase stood out to you or how it might impact your day.

[4] You can download the Grace App for Apple at https://apps.apple.com/us/app/id1512449655 or on Android at https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=org.trygrace.gracecshurch..